

Embervale

Visual direction and design system for a mobile-first fantasy hero and card battler. This is the authoritative reference for all future design work on the product.

Everything in this document has been approved. Where a decision is still open it appears in the final section, marked as an open task. Anything not written here is not yet decided, and anything listed under *Rejected directions* should not be revisited without a deliberate conversation.

1 · What the game is

A fast lane-based hero and card battler, played in portrait on a phone. The player builds a fifteen-card deck, draws up to three cards, and fills three hero lanes and three spell lanes. Heroes persist on the board between rounds. Higher power defeats lower power; equal power destroys both heroes; an empty enemy hero lane takes direct damage. One-time spells resolve and go to the graveyard, continuous spells stay locked in their slot. Spells resolve before hero combat, effects target automatically, and lane placement determines who a card affects. The player presses one button to resolve the round.

The interaction loop is three steps and never more: **choose a card, place it in a lane, press Fight**. There is no manual targeting for normal effects and no confirmation step.

The rules are settled and are not a design concern. Design work covers presentation, layout, hierarchy, usability, character presentation and mobile polish. No new systems, screens or mechanics should be introduced by a design pass.

The product is a React and TypeScript prototype. Card data lives in `src/game/cards`, split by faction, and the icon family lives in `src/components/Icon.tsx`. Design work should read from those files rather than invent parallel data. Note that the codebase carries a fourth faction, Wildborn, which the original brief omitted.

2 · Approved visual direction

The direction is called **Embervale**. It is a warm sunset fantasy realm rendered in carved wood, hammered gold and dusk-lit stone. It is the approved direction and no alternative styling should be proposed on top of it.

Four principles define it.

The world is the background layer. Every screen sits on a painted environment — a sunset sky over distant hills on Home, a lit arena floor in battle, a dusk-toned hall in the collection screens. The environment is drawn with large soft gradient masses, silhouetted ridgelines and one dominant light source. UI floats above it. There is no flat page colour anywhere in the product.

Characters are the visual stars. On Home a single hero occupies roughly half the frame, backlit, with the environment glowing behind them. Nothing in the interface may cross a hero's face or chest. Supporting UI arranges itself around the figure rather than on top of it.

UI is made of objects, not panels. Interface elements read as physical things in the world: carved wooden banners, gold medallions, pressed metal seals, ribbon plates, engraved dividers. Rounded rectangular containers are used sparingly and never stacked into a grid. Where a container is genuinely needed it is shaped — notched, angled or bevelled — not a plain rounded box.

Light does the work. Depth comes from lighting rather than borders: rim light along the top edge of raised objects, a dark bottom edge, a soft cast shadow, and a warm glow behind anything important. Hairlines are warm gold at low alpha, never neutral grey.

Atmosphere is present but restrained: drifting motes rising through the frame, a slow breathing glow behind the primary action, and a light sweep across card art. Motion is brisk and cheap. Nothing loops fast enough to distract during play.

3 • Colour system

The palette is warm throughout. Cool colour appears only as faction accent and as the sky in an environment gradient. Two rules govern it: the accent is gold and gold alone, and no more than two background colour families appear in a single screen.

CORE

Token	Value	Use
World base	#150D13	Deepest ground behind every environment
Ink	#FFF6E6	Primary text, warm off-white
Ink secondary	#C8A98F	Supporting copy, metadata
Ink muted	#A98D78	Smallest captions. Floor for text contrast — nothing dimmer
Gold light	#FFE6AD	Top of every metal gradient, rim light
Gold	#FFD894	Accent, headings on dark, active state
Gold deep	#A9701F	Bottom of metal gradients
Gold ink	#3D2210	Text sitting on gold
Wood	#7A4630 → #42221A	Carved banners, name plates, the HUD arc
Ember	#E8674F → #8F2E2C	The Fight seal core, and only that
Success	#9FE8C0	Player health, positive buffs, victory
Danger	#F0857A	Enemy health, defeat, destructive actions

Metal recipe. Every gold object uses the same construction so it reads as one material: a vertical gradient from `#FFE6AD` to `#A9701F`, a one-pixel white highlight inset at the top, a dark inset at the bottom, and a drop shadow in `rgba(20,8,6,.6)`. Flat gold fills are not used.

Hairlines. Divider and edge strokes are warm gold at low alpha — `rgba(255,214,140,.13)` for the quietest, `.45` for a lit edge. Neutral grey borders are not part of this system.

4 • Typography

Two families, used strictly by role. **Bree Serif** is the display face: hero names, card names, screen titles, stat numerals, button labels. **Nunito** carries everything else: body copy, ability text, metadata, chips, captions. Bree Serif is never used for a paragraph, and Nunito is never used for a hero name.

Role	Face and size	Where
Display	Bree Serif 27–36	Featured hero name, modal titles
Screen title	Bree Serif 27–29	Heroes, Decks, Profile headers
Section title	Bree Serif 17–19, gold	In-page group headings, paired with a fading rule
Card name	Bree Serif 15–17	On the carved plate; wraps to two lines rather than truncating
Stat numeral	Bree Serif 16–34	Power seals, health readouts, counters
Body	Nunito 600, 13.5–15	Ability text, help copy, descriptions
Card ability	Nunito 600, 11.5–12	Short summary only, two lines maximum
Caption	Nunito 700–800, 11.5–13	Chips, faction lines, metadata

Small uppercase utility labels are rejected. Tracked-out micro-caps such as **ACTIVE DECK** or **FEATURED HERO** were the strongest signal that the earlier design read as a dashboard. Sections are titled in Bree Serif at sentence case, or they carry no label at all and rely on layout to communicate grouping. Sentence case is the default everywhere; title case appears only in proper names.

5 • Home screen

Home answers one question within a second: *what do I do next?* It contains five things and no more — player identity, one dominant featured hero, the selected deck, one primary battle action, and the navigation HUD.

Environment. A sunset gradient runs the full height, from pale gold at the top through amber and rose into deep violet. A sun disc sits behind the hero with a broad radial bloom. Two silhouetted mountain ridges cross the middle distance and a green foreground bluff curves across the base. Light shafts fall diagonally through the frame and motes drift upward.

The hero. A backlit bust occupies roughly 54% of the frame height, centred, with a warm halo behind. The figure is built as sloped shoulders, a bridging neck and a helmeted head, masked into the background at the base so it emerges from the scene rather than sitting on it. Rim light is warm on one side and cool on the other. No interface element crosses the face or chest.

Identity. Top left: a circular gold-ringed portrait with a level badge notched into its lower edge, the player name in Bree Serif, and rank beneath in warm ink. A dark scrim runs behind the top band so this text always clears contrast against a bright sky. A round gold settings medallion sits opposite, top right.

Deck crest. Below the identity block on the left, a shield-shaped faction crest with a ribbon plate running off its right edge carrying the deck name and card count. Tapping it opens the deck builder. It is a hanging sign, not a card.

Hero nameplate. A carved wooden banner with notched ends, swaying very slowly, crossing the lower torso of the figure. It carries the hero name in Bree Serif and the faction and role beneath, flanked by faction diamonds. Tapping it opens that hero's card detail. The power medallion sits separately on the right flank so nothing stacks on the chest.

HUD and the Fight seal. The bottom bar is a carved wooden arc with a gold top edge, rising above the screen base and curving at its upper corners. Four circular medallions sit in it — Home, Heroes, Decks, Profile — the active one in polished gold with dark ink, the rest in dark wood with a gold ring. In the centre, breaking above the arc, sits the **Fight seal**: a large gold ring around an ember-red core with the word Fight in Bree Serif and a slow breathing halo behind it. It is a pressed seal set into the HUD, not a button laid on top of the layout, and it is the single largest interactive element on the screen.

6 • Card design

One frame family serves every card in every context. The card must work in the hand, in the deck builder, in the collection grid, in the detail modal, and as a compact board piece. It should read as something a player would want to pull, not as a UI tile.

ANATOMY, TOP TO BOTTOM

Art area. Roughly 65% of the card height. Nothing overlaps the face. A gradient scrim covers only the lowest third of the art so the plate can sit against it. A slow specular light sweep passes across the art, which keeps placeholder art from feeling dead.

Gem row and rarity word. Top left, a row of four diamond slots with the filled count indicating rarity. Top right, the rarity name in Bree Serif. Two independent signals, neither of which depends on colour.

Name plate. A notched wooden banner that breaks the frame line at the art boundary, carrying the card name in Bree Serif. It wraps to two lines rather than truncating.

Power seal. A raised gold coin straddling the art and the plate, always the same relative size and position on every hero card. Power must be findable without reading. Heroes are the only card type carrying a number here.

Faction line. Sigil tile, faction name and role on a single baseline beneath the plate.

Ability line. A short summary of a handful of words, two lines maximum. The full rules text lives only in the detail view. This is what keeps type large enough to read on a phone.

THE THREE CARD TYPES

Hero. Character portrait, gold power seal, role in the faction line. The presence of a numbered gold coin is the type's defining mark.

Spell. No portrait. The art is a radiant rune sigil composition. In place of the power seal sits a violet-framed type token carrying the spell mark. A spell card must never read as a hero card with the number removed.

Continuous spell. Three simultaneous marks, because colour alone is not permitted to carry this: a *gold* type token holding the continuous glyph, a slowly rotating dashed rune ring inside the art, and a gold *Continuous* banner across the artwork. A player must recognise "this stays on the field" instantly.

BOARD PIECES

On the battlefield a card becomes a chit roughly 110 points wide. It carries portrait, power seal, short name and a small gem row, plus a status pill above the name when a modifier applies. Ability text is dropped entirely. Names use the `shortName` field that already exists in the card data, so nothing truncates mid-word. Spell chits carry the name on one line and the kind label with its continuous glyph on a second line beneath — the glyph is never a floating corner badge competing with the name for width. Chits are angled slabs, clipped along their vertical edges so the player's row and the enemy's row lean toward each other.

7 • Rarity

Four tiers, and four stacked signals so that rarity survives greyscale, colour blindness and a small screen. Colour alone is never the carrier. Common must still look worth keeping; Legendary must feel like a pull.

Tier	Gems	Frame	Ornament and glow
Common	1	Plain iron, 2px	None. Clean and quiet
Rare	2	Steel blue, 2.5px	Notched top corners
Epic	3	Violet, 3px	Filigree upper corners, soft outer glow
Legendary	4	Gold, 3.5px	Crown ornament above, lower corner brackets, pulsing aura, drifting motes, brighter art light

Rarity always outranks faction in the visual hierarchy. A common Kingdom card and a legendary Kingdom card must be distinguishable at a glance across a grid; two legendaries of different factions need not be.

8 • Factions

Faction is restrained identification, never a theme applied to the whole interface. It owns exactly three things: the light colour in the card art, the sigil shape, and one accent line of text. It never touches frame weight, the power seal, or the surrounding UI.

Faction	Accent	Sigil	Identity
Kingdom	#7FB6F0	Diamond	Knights, priests, archers. Buffs, protection, board control. Cool down light, banner ribbon detail. Noble and aspirational
Undead	#7FD8B0	Ring	Skeletons, wraiths, necromancers. Death triggers, revival, graveyard. Pale underlight, bone hairline. Creepy and stylish rather than gory
Infernal	#F0866A	Spike	Demons, fire creatures, corrupted warriors. Aggression, direct damage, power reduction. Ember rim light, cracked edge. Dangerous and flashy
Wildborn	#B7D474	Leaf	Beasts and nature spirits. Growth, high power, lane movement. Green dapple light, woodgrain edge. Present in the codebase; absent from the original brief

Spells carry a faction for flavour only, since any deck may include any spell. On a spell card the faction appears as a subdued text line, never as a frame treatment.

9 • Battle screen

The highest-priority screen. It must fit 390 × 844 with no scrolling and no bottom navigation. A brand-new player should be able to infer the rules from the layout alone.

Environment. A dusk arena: a warm gradient sky, a distant ridgeline with two banner poles, and a large lit stage floor curving up from the base in warm ochre. A soft pool of light falls across the centre of the board.

Vertical order. Enemy banner with health bar; enemy hero row; enemy spell row; the clash divider; player spell row; player hero row; the player's health and resource strip; the hand; the Fight seal.

Lanes. Each lane is one vertical column of a three-column grid, holding all four of its slots. The structure itself must carry the lane relationship — left, centre and right text labels are not sufficient and are not used. The mid-board divider is an ornamental rule with a lit diamond at each lane's centre line, which reinforces the columns while separating the two sides.

Hero slots. Larger than spell slots, angled slabs, portrait-led, with the power seal at the top right and the short name across the base. Empty slots show a hero silhouette glyph and the words *Drop hero* in a dashed gold frame — never a plain grey box.

Spell slots. Shorter, angled the opposite way so the pairing with the hero beneath is visible, and clearly attached to one lane. Occupied slots show the name on one line and the kind on the next. Continuous spells get the gold locked-slot treatment plus the glyph and label.

The hand. Three cards fanned across a warm apron at the base of the screen — the outer two rotated outward, the centre card raised and forward. Selecting a card lifts and scales it and rings it in gold. Each card shows art, name, rarity gems, type, power if a hero, and a short effect line.

Placement feedback. With a card selected, valid slots light gold and pulse, invalid slots dim to about 55% opacity, and the lane diamond brightens. A hint line above the hand reads *Tap a hero slot* or *Tap a spell slot*. Placement snaps the card in with a brief scale animation.

Fight. The same gold and ember seal as on Home, set into the hand apron and overlapping the centre card. During resolution it desaturates to cold metal, the glow stops, planning interactions are disabled and the status band above the board reads *Resolving*. There is no second confirmation control anywhere on this screen.

Readouts. Health bars are chunky gold-rimmed vessels with the numeral inside — green for the player, red for the enemy. Graveyard and deck counts sit in two small pill counters beside the player bar.

10 • Other screens

Battle setup. Full-bleed, no bottom navigation. Your deck presented on a carved banner with its counts and average power, a horizontal strip of card spines beneath, a large ornamental *versus* divider, then the opponent as a shield-framed portrait with faction, archetype and a one-line read on how they play. A wide hexagonal Fight plate below, and a quieter underlined link to start with the tutorial.

Heroes. A collection, not an admin table. Search in a pill field, then faction chips, rarity chips and a hero/spell segmented row, all as rounded gold-lit pills. A three-column grid of full card frames follows, with a count of matches. Tapping any card opens the detail sheet.

Card detail. A rising sheet with a large portrait panel, the gem row and rarity word, the power seal or spell type token, the name and faction line over the art, then the full ability text under a gold *Ability* heading and a flavour line set in italic against a gold rule. This view must feel rewarding enough that seeing a newly pulled Legendary here is a moment.

Decks. Deck name and faction, a large count against fifteen that turns green when legal, a hero and spell split bar, a four-column rarity distribution, then the deck as a four-column grid of mini cards with copy counts — tap to remove. Below, the collection as a scannable list with a gold plus

medallion per row; rows dim and the medallion goes inert when a card is at its two-copy limit or the deck is full.

Profile. Deliberately light. Avatar with level badge, name, rank and battle count, then Settings and How to play as two large tappable rows. No progression systems. Developer tools sit below a dashed rule in a visually separate group and never mix with player controls.

Help. A compact sheet that teaches visually. A three-lane diagram showing the enemy hero, enemy spell, divider, player spell and player hero stack; then four comparison rows using numerals rather than sentences ($5 > 3$, $4 = 4$, $3 \rightarrow$ heart, hero + spell); then one-time and continuous spells side by side with their glyphs; then the Fight seal with a single line on resolution order. No walls of text.

Tutorial overlay. Four steps on the battle screen, each dimming the background and lifting exactly one target above the scrim with a gold ring and a pulse: the hand, then the hero slots, then the spell slots, then the Fight seal. A small wooden tooltip card carries a step counter, a title, one sentence, a skip link and a next button, positioned so it never covers the element it is describing.

11 • Iconography

The product has one icon family and it already exists: the hand-authored 24×24 stroke set in `src/components/Icon.tsx`. Design work must use those exact glyph paths rather than draw substitutes. Note that `public/icons.svg` is Vite starter boilerplate containing social logos and is not the game icon set.

The set covers navigation (home, battle, heroes, decks, profile), game concepts (hero, spell, continuous spell, power, hp, deck, graveyard) and utility (settings, search, filter, back, close, help). Icons are stroked in `currentColor` at 1.5–2.1 weight with round caps and joins. The spell mark is the radiant orb and the continuous spell mark is the circle with a loop arrow; these two are the load-bearing glyphs in the whole product and should not be replaced.

12 • Mobile constraints

Primary viewport is 390×844 portrait. These are hard requirements, not preferences.

- The battle screen never scrolls.
- Tap targets are 44 points or larger.
- The hand and the Fight seal stay in the lower third, within thumb reach.
- Bottom navigation is hidden during battle and battle setup; those are full-screen.
- Card stats stay legible at chit size; if text will not fit, it is cut rather than shrunk.
- No text truncates mid-word. Names either wrap to two lines or use the `shortName` field.

- Body text holds 4.5:1 contrast against whatever sits behind it, including painted environments — which is why the top of Home carries a scrim.

Desktop. The player experience stays mobile-first, centred in a narrow column with a device frame. A dashed developer panel may sit alongside it showing live state and reset controls. The game is never redesigned as a desktop-first layout.

13 • UI principles

Apply these when a decision is not covered elsewhere in this document.

- **Clarity beats decoration.** If an ornamental choice makes the game harder to read, it goes.
 - **Never signal with colour alone.** Rarity, spell type and state each carry at least two independent cues.
 - **One primary action per screen.** Everything else is visibly quieter.
 - **Objects, not panels.** Before adding a rounded rectangle, ask what physical thing it could be instead.
 - **Structure over labels.** If a relationship needs a caption to be understood, the layout is wrong.
 - **Short copy, sentence case, plain language.** No heavy lore or invented fantasy vocabulary in the interface.
 - **Motion is brisk.** Card lift 160ms, snap into lane 280ms, power bump 400ms, modal rise 260ms, press 90ms. No cinematic sequences.
 - **Empty states are designed.** An empty slot shows what belongs there and invites the action.
 - **Placeholder art must look intentional.** The layout has to hold up before final art arrives.
 - **One developer must be able to build it.** Practical beats impressive.
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14 • Rejected directions

These were tried, judged, and ruled out. Do not reintroduce them.

- **Dashboard and SaaS layouts.** A flat dark background with a vertical stack of rounded rectangular panels. This was the central failure of the first pass and is the thing to guard against hardest.
- **Flat single-colour backgrounds.** Including the dark purple that replaced the earlier slate. Every screen carries a painted environment.
- **Tracked-out uppercase micro-labels.** Section headings are Bree Serif in sentence case, or absent.
- **Web-style CTA buttons.** The primary action is a seal set into the world, never a full-width rounded rectangle.

- **Generic app tab bars.** Navigation is a carved HUD arc with medallions.
- **Cool neutral greys, grey hairlines and grey empty slots.** Neutrals are warm; empty slots are designed.
- **Full rules text on the card face.** Cards carry a short line; full text is in the detail view.
- **Corner badges that compete with a name for width.** The continuous glyph sits inline with the kind label.
- **Theming the whole interface by faction.** Faction stays inside card accents, sigils, filters and deck badges.
- **Left / centre / right lane labels.** The column structure carries it.
- **Extra confirm or cast buttons in battle.** One Fight press per round.
- **Cluttered MMO chrome, ornate TCG frames, overdone grimdark, rainbow or neon palettes, tiny text, every panel a different colour.**
- **New systems.** Shop, summon, quests, events and guilds are out of scope until asked for. No progression systems on Profile.
- **Two rejected concept directions:** *Ashen Vigil*, a rain-and-iron cinematic treatment with engraved caps and hexagonal plates; and *Aetherfall*, an ethereal floating-isle treatment with aurora light and rotating rune halos. Both were fully explored and set aside in favour of Embervale.

15 • Open design tasks

Everything above is settled. These remain.

Card art direction and anchor set. The largest open task. Character imagery is still placeholder — geometric backlit busts that prove the composition but do not make a player want the card. The need is a locked art style plus nine to twelve anchor artworks covering the range of collector appeal: a noble hero, an elegant caster, a cute or mascot character, a creepy undead, a cool necromancer, a demon warrior, a flashy infernal caster, at least two chase-feel cards, and at least one physically imposing figure. Art should be stylised and semi-painterly, character-focused with a strong silhouette, on a simple supporting background, readable at hand-card size. Consistency across the set matters more than individual impressiveness. One-time spell art should read as an active burst; continuous spell art as an anchored, environmental object such as a banner, totem, altar or shrine.

Wildborn. The fourth faction has provisional styling — leaf sigil, green dapple light — but no confirmation that it belongs in the shipped product. Confirm or cut.

Power and hp glyphs. The icon set carries both, but the power seal currently shows a bare numeral and the health bars show numerals only. Decide whether the glyphs earn their place or whether numerals alone are cleaner.

Real hero art pipeline. Whether cards eventually take drop-in image slots for supplied artwork, or the styled placeholder treatment ships as-is for playtesting. This decision shapes the frame's art area spec.

Combat resolution feedback. Motion rules exist for defeat and revival, but the moment-to-moment choreography of a resolving round — what the player watches between pressing Fight and seeing the outcome — has not been designed.

Victory and defeat screens. Not yet designed. The battle screen currently only changes its status band.

Scaling the roster. The card system has been proven against a sample. It has not been stress-tested against the full thirty to forty cards — particularly the longest names and the wordiest abilities.

Housekeeping. Three superseded exploration files and one obsolete first-pass file still sit in the design project and should be removed once the team is settled: **Concept A/B/C** and **Battler Redesign**. The live files are **Embervale** (the screen prototype) and **Card System** (the card specification).